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Life-crisis rituals among the Kenuz

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After dinner on the sabaheya, he received small amounts of money from his male relatives and friends, each person giving from three to five piastres. Although this money was described as nokut, it was given without the usual formality, and it was not recorded. Apparently there was no obligation to repay it.

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The financial aspects of this period were complex. The shelah gifts had conceptually discharged, in advance, all the household expenses for which a groom could be held responsible during the period of time extending 40 days after his wedding. But these items consisted only of such staples as he, his wife, and his guests might consume. A groom's special status also resembled the treatment of a woman after delivery by requiring a particularly rich diet. This consisted of foods regarded as exceptionally nourishing, in quantities much greater than those normally eaten in Dahmit. He ate four full meals each day, including a pair of pigeons stuffed with cracked wheat which his wife brought with her each night. Neighbors and other village women brought his mother-in-law eggs, chickens, pigeons, milk, and butter as gifts which she had to repay on similar occasions in the future. These were not sufficient. In practice, a groom provided money with which she bought the special food he required, but the true nature of such payments was carefully concealed.

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On the sabaheya morning, after his mother-in-law had sent him a glass of milk containing a quantity of melted butter, he sent his sword to her. She returned

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it by a messenger, who also brought him a note for £E 1 from her. The groom returned this money, adding another £E 1 note.

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His main expense and largest contribution was agilbaygit, which he paid the bride. This first occurred on the night following their wedding, after the women who brought her to their room left the couple alone. When he addressed her, she made no response. He handed her money to induce her to speak. Her mother or another relative had told how much money she should hold out for, and warned her not to break her silence until she received this amount. By the rules of the game, he had to pay her only the sum he had offered up to the point where she spoke. In practice, however, her mother required a certain amount. If he tricked the daughter into talking prematurely, she simply repeated the same performance on the next night. If the notes that he gave her at first were not enough, she threw them down. He picked them up and added more, until he reached the sum she had been told to accept. She then spoke. Some men paid all the agilbaygit, which averaged about £E 8, on the first night. Usually they repeated the same performance until the sebu, the bride receiving a smaller amount each night. For example, a man might give her £E 5 the first night, £E 2 the second, and £E 1 the third. She gave all the agilbaygit to her mother.

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Agilbaygit means literally "opening the mouth." Most Kenuz seemed to view the transaction in these terms. Like the groom's opening his wife's shogga on their wedding night, it was regarded as a contest. A man might try to trick his wife into speaking by asking her how much money she wanted, and she had been warned to respond to any questions with gestures. A woman who spoke prematurely was teased. One who could make her husband give more money than the amount needed was admired as very clever. This practice was also a common source of amusement and the subject of standard jokes among women, such as speculating about how much agilbaygit a man might give before he realized that he had married a woman who was dumb.

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Yet one inevitably wonders whether “speaking” might be a euphemism for intercourse, and whether the mouth signified the vagina. At first such an interpretation seems unlikely, if for no other reason than the complete lack of such euphemisms in ordinary conversation among women. Kenuz women discussed sex frequently, with an explicitness in terms and gestures that sometimes embarrassed outsiders. Thus, while CC was focussing a camera as FG and two of her friends were posing for a  67 photograph, one of them shouted, “When does the fucking start?” In this case, she was at least as embarrassed as he when she realized that he understood the meaning of *zigzig*. Moreover, marriage was rarely consummated on the first night after the wedding, when the main amount of agilbaygit was paid.

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